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2027 CYCLE

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CUET UG

Political Science

Globalisation and its Critics

Official Syllabus · Contemporary World Politics · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Contemporary World Politics)	Skills the questions test
Concept & Political Dimensions	Political manifestations: erosion of the welfare state, rise of the minimal state, and enhanced state technological capacity.	Analyzing the impact of globalization on state sovereignty, regulatory power, surveillance technology, and law-and-order functions.
Economic Manifestations	Economic manifestations: trade deregulation, capital mobility, and unequal distributional impacts.	Contrasting free capital/commodity flows with restricted human labor migration; evaluating the role of the WTO, World Bank, and IMF.
Cultural Manifestations	Cultural manifestations: cultural homogenisation versus cultural heterogenisation.	Distinguishing 'McDonaldization' and cultural imperialism from creative cultural hybridity and local enrichment (heterogenisation).
Anti-Globalisation Movements	Anti-globalisation movements: the 1999 Seattle protests and the World Social Forum (WSF).	Tracing the 1999 Seattle WTO protests, the origins of the WSF in Porto Alegre (2001), and the 4th WSF in Mumbai (2004).
Ideological Critiques	Debates on the nature of consequences of globalization: Left versus Right ideological critiques.	Differentiating Left economic critiques (corporate exploitation, inequality) from Right socio-cultural critiques (traditional values, cultural purity).

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Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Contemporary World Politics)	Skills the questions test
India & Globalisation	India as an arena of globalization and struggles against it.	Evaluating the 1991 New Economic Policy (LPG), resistance by central trade unions, and agrarian struggles against WTO patent regimes.

CUET UG Exam Strategy — Chapter 7 Focus (World Politics)

- **Pattern:** 50 Multiple Choice Questions (attempt any 40) in 60 minutes.
- **Marking:** +5 marks for correct choice, −1 mark negative deduction for incorrect choice.
- **High-Yield Angles:** Venues of the World Social Forum (1st in Porto Alegre 2001, 4th in Mumbai 2004), Cultural Homogenisation vs Heterogenisation, 1999 Seattle WTO protests, and Indian domestic resistance.

1. The Concept and Nature of Globalisation

Globalisation is fundamentally a multi-dimensional concept that deals with the worldwide interconnectedness and accelerated **"flows"** of four core elements across international frontiers:

- **1. Ideas:** Ideologies, philosophies, scientific knowledge, and information moving seamlessly via digital networks.
- **2. Capital:** Foreign Direct Investment (FDI), portfolio equity, and international loans moving across national boundaries.
- **3. Commodities:** Raw materials, agricultural goods, and manufactured industrial products traded between countries.
- **4. People:** Human labor, students, professionals, and migrants traveling abroad in search of education, employment, and livelihoods.

Crucial Enablers of Contemporary Globalisation

- **Technological Revolution:** While international trade existed along ancient routes (such as the Silk Road), contemporary globalisation is uniquely driven by modern technology—microprocessors, fiber-optic cables, satellite telecommunications, high-speed aviation, and the internet.
- **Global Interconnectedness:** Events occurring in one geographic corner of the globe (e.g., a subprime mortgage collapse in the US, a viral outbreak in Wuhan, or a war in Ukraine) trigger instantaneous social, political, and economic repercussions across the entire planet.

2. Political Manifestations of Globalisation

How does globalisation reshape the traditional authority, sovereignty, and functions of the modern nation-state?

The Debate Over State Sovereignty and Capacity

- **1. Erosion of the Welfare State (The Minimal State):**
  - Globalisation tends to retreat the state from its traditional socio-economic welfare functions.
  - Under neo-liberal market discipline, governments withdraw from direct commercial manufacturing, public healthcare subsidies, price controls, and social housing.
  - The state shifts toward a **"minimal state"**, focusing primarily on preserving internal law and order and defending national sovereignty from external aggression.
- **2. Sovereignty is NOT Obsolete:**
  - Political scientists emphasize that globalisation has **not destroyed state sovereignty**.
  - The nation-state remains the supreme legal authority with a constitutional monopoly on the legitimate use of coercive physical force within its borders.
  - In moments of global crisis (such as the 2008 financial meltdown or the 2020 COVID-19 pandemic), citizens turn to the sovereign state, not multinational corporations, for rescue.
- **3. Enhanced State Administrative Capacity:**
  - Advanced digital technologies (biometric databases, satellite intelligence, facial recognition, electronic surveillance, and big-data analytics) have actually made the modern state **far more powerful** in monitoring citizens, maintaining domestic security, and collecting taxes.

3. Economic Manifestations of Globalisation

Economic globalisation refers to the expanding integration of national economies through the removal of barriers to trade, investment, and capital flows.

Key Features of Economic Globalisation

- **Trade and Investment Liberalisation:** Sashing of peak import customs tariffs, abolition of import quotas, dismantling of currency exchange controls, and opening of domestic sectors to Foreign Direct Investment (FDI).
- **Institutional Enforcers:** Governed and accelerated by international financial and trade institutions: the **World Trade Organization (WTO)**, the **International Monetary Fund (IMF)**, and the **World Bank**.

The Great Distributional Divide: Winners and Losers

- **Economic Polarisation:** Economic globalisation does not benefit all citizens or countries equally:

- **The Beneficiaries ("Winners"):** Transnational corporations, high-tech professionals, financial investors, and competitive export-oriented manufacturing firms.
- **The Marginalized ("Losers"):** Small artisanal producers, unorganized rural laborers, subsistence farmers, and public sector workers who lose employment as inefficient domestic factories close.

- **The Asymmetry of Global Mobility:**
  - While capital, financial investments, and manufactured consumer goods are permitted to flow with near-zero friction across borders, the **movement of human labor is severely restricted**.
  - Industrialized Western countries erect formidable passport controls, visa quotas, border walls, and deportation regimes to prevent workers from the Global South from entering their labor markets.

4. Cultural Manifestations: Homogenisation vs Heterogenisation

The cultural impact of globalisation is deeply complex and contradictory, producing both standardization and vibrant diversity.

Cultural Homogenisation (The Uniformity Danger)

- **Rise of a Monoculture:** The global spread of Western, predominantly American, consumer culture, lifestyles, values, and tastes.
- **McDonaldization:** Sociologist George Ritzer coined this term to describe the worldwide expansion of fast-food chains, consumer brands, blue jeans, Hollywood films, and Western pop music.
- **Cultural Imperialism:** Critics argue that cultural homogenisation is not a neutral, benign exchange; it represents the soft-power hegemony of the wealthy West over weak, indigenous cultures, threatening to erase regional languages, traditional culinary practices, and ancestral heritage.

Cultural Heterogenisation (The Hybridity Alternative)

- **Creative Blending:** Cultures do not simply collapse or surrender when exposed to external influences; they actively modify and adapt incoming foreign elements to local cultural contexts.
- **Syncretic Hybridity:** Incoming external cultures combine with traditional domestic customs to produce entirely novel, hybrid forms.
- **Everyday Examples:**
  - Eating a spicy vegetable or paneer burger alongside traditional masala dosa and idli.
  - Wearing a traditional khadi kurta over modern denim blue jeans.
- **Cultural Enrichment:** External interactions do not necessarily destroy traditional cultures; they can expand human choices, introduce new creative possibilities, and make local cultures richer and more resilient.

5. Anti-Globalisation Movements and the World Social Forum

The uneven, disruptive consequences of globalisation have ignited intense political opposition from diverse ideological and social constituencies across the world.

Ideological Critiques of Globalisation

- **The Leftist Critique:**
  - Denounces economic globalisation as a predatory form of contemporary corporate neo-liberal capitalism.
  - Argues that it enriches a tiny global elite (the top 1%) while impoverishing the working masses, weakening labor unions, destroying the environment, and commodifying basic human necessities like water, healthcare, and education.
- **The Rightist Critique:**
  - Expresses deep anxiety over the political and cultural dimensions of globalisation.
  - Fears that economic interdependence undermines national sovereignty, erodes traditional family values, dilutes patriotic national identity, and introduces decadent Western cultural habits.

Historic Anti-Globalisation Turning Points

- **The "Battle of Seattle" (November 1999):**
  - Over 50,000 civil society activists, environmentalists, labor unionists, and consumer advocates staged massive, coordinated street protests that paralyzed downtown Seattle, forcing the collapse of the **3rd WTO Ministerial Conference**.
  - Marked the dramatic arrival of the global anti-globalisation movement onto international prime-time television.
- **The World Social Forum (WSF):**
  - Conceived in 2001 as a direct democratic counter-pole to the elite, corporate-dominated **World Economic Forum (WEF)** that meets annually in Davos, Switzerland.
  - Operates under the inspirational banner: **"Another World is Possible"**.
  - A massive global gathering bringing together environmentalists, human rights campaigners, feminists, indigenous leaders, and labor unions to explore equitable, sustainable economic alternatives.
  - **Inaugural Meeting (2001):** Convened in **Porto Alegre, Brazil**, in January 2001.
  - **The 4th WSF in Mumbai (2004):** In January 2004, the Fourth World Social Forum met in **Mumbai, India**, mobilizing hundreds of thousands of Indian trade unionists, Dalits, adivasis, and peasant organizers.

6. India and the Dynamics of Globalisation

India's historical relationship with global economic integration is marked by a dramatic transition from colonial exploitation to post-independence autarky, and finally to selective integration.

Historical Trajectory

- **The Colonial Experience:** Under British imperial rule, India was forcibly transformed from a major exporter of high-value manufactured textiles into a raw-material supplier (cotton, indigo, jute) and an open market for manufactured British industrial goods.
- **Post-Independence Self-Reliance (Swadeshi):** Traumatized by colonial plunder, independent India adopted an inward-looking policy of **import-substitution industrialization (ISI)** and the "Licence-Permit-Quota Raj" to nurture domestic industries, restricting foreign investment.
- **The 1991 LPG Turning Point:** Facing a severe balance of payments crisis in June 1991, Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao and Finance Minister Dr. Manmohan Singh initiated structural economic reforms (LPG), opening the economy to global capital and trade.

Multi-Sectoral Resistance to Globalisation in India

- **Trade Union Mobilisation:**
  - Central trade unions across political parties (CITU, AITUC, BMS, INTUC) organized nationwide general strikes protesting the disinvestment of profitable Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs), contractualisation of permanent labor, and dilution of labor protective laws.
- **Agrarian Protests and Biopiracy Battles:**
  - Peasant organizations—including the **Bharatiya Kisan Union (BKU)** and the **Karnataka Rajya Raitha Sangha (KRRS)**—fiercely agitated against the entry of multinational seed giants (such as Monsanto) and opposed WTO intellectual property rules (**TRIPS**).
  - Indian legal and civil society successfully challenged foreign patents granted on indigenous Indian botanical resources:
    - **Neem Tree:** US patent on fungicidal properties successfully revoked.
    - **Basmati Rice:** Texas firm RiceTec's patent on Basmati lines successfully challenged.
    - **Turmeric:** US patent on wound-healing properties overturned using ancient Ayurvedic texts.
- **Socio-Cultural Backlash:**
  - Right-wing groups (such as the **Swadeshi Jagran Manch**) and cultural traditionalists protested against Western consumerism, commercialization of higher education, and Western cultural events (such as Valentine's Day celebrations and beauty pageants).

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The Whole Chapter in One Picture



Figure 1: Globalisation and its Critics Mindmap: Multi-dimensional flows, political state capacity, economic inequalities, cultural homogenisation vs heterogenisation, and WSF.



Figure 2: Contestation Matrix: The World Social Forum architecture, chronology of resistance (Seattle to Mumbai), and three arenas of anti-globalisation in India.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Ten questions designed in authentic CUET UG single-correct style. The official marking scheme awards +5 for each correct answer and deducts −1 for every incorrect answer.

Q1. Globalisation fundamentally deals with interconnected 'flows' across borders. Which of the following is NOT one of the four core flows?

(A) Flow of Ideas
(B) Flow of Capital
(C) Flow of Commodities
(D) Flow of Sovereign Territory

Q2. In political terminology, the reduction of state activities to core functions such as maintaining law, order, and national security is referred to as:

(A) The Totalitarian State
(B) The Minimal State
(C) The Welfare State
(D) The Feudal State

Q3. The worldwide expansion of standardized Western fast-food chains, consumer brands, and lifestyles is popularly analyzed as:

(A) Cultural Heterogenisation
(B) Cultural Homogenisation (McDonaldization)
(C) Cultural Relativism
(D) Cultural Pluralism

Q4. The creative blending of external cultural elements with local traditions (such as wearing a khadi kurta over blue jeans) is termed:

(A) Cultural Homogenisation
(B) Cultural Imperialism
(C) Cultural Heterogenisation
(D) Ethnocentrism

Q5. In which city did massive street protests by 50,000 civil society activists shut down the WTO Ministerial Conference in November 1999?

(A) Geneva
(B) Seattle
(C) Davos
(D) Cancun

Q6. The World Social Forum (WSF) was established in 2001 under which famous rallying slogan?

(A) Workers of the World Unite
(B) Another World is Possible
(C) Free Trade for All
(D) Make In India

Q7. In which country was the first inaugural summit of the World Social Forum (WSF) convened in January 2001?

(A) Porto Alegre, Brazil
(B) Mumbai, India
(C) Geneva, Switzerland
(D) Nairobi, Kenya

Q8. The fourth meeting of the World Social Forum (WSF), which mobilized massive participation from Indian civil society, took place in which city in 2004?

(A) New Delhi
(B) Kolkata
(C) Mumbai
(D) Bengaluru

Q9. In which year did India formally launch structural economic adjustment reforms under the New Economic Policy (LPG)?

(A) 1977
(B) 1985
(C) 1991
(D) 1998

Q10. Indian civil society and legal authorities famously challenged and overturned foreign patents granted on which indigenous botanical resources?

(A) Wheat, Rice, and Barley
(B) Neem, Turmeric, and Basmati Rice
(C) Tea, Coffee, and Rubber
(D) Sugarcane, Mustard, and Cotton

Detailed Solutions

Sol. Q1. Globalisation involves the transnational movement of ideas, capital, commodities, and people. Sovereign territory does not flow; state physical boundaries remain legally fixed.

Answer: (D)

Sol. Q2. Under economic globalization, states often retreat from welfare functions to become a 'minimal state' focused primarily on defending borders and enforcing basic contracts and law.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q3. Cultural homogenisation, also termed 'McDonaldization', describes the global spread of uniform Western consumer culture and commercial products threatening local cultures.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q4. Cultural heterogenisation (or cultural hybridity) describes the creative process whereby external influences are modified and fused with indigenous cultural practices.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q5. In November 1999, the 'Battle of Seattle' erupted when 50,000 protesters blocked and disrupted the 3rd Ministerial Conference of the WTO in Seattle, USA.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q6. The World Social Forum (WSF) was founded under the global slogan 'Another World is Possible', advocating an alternative, democratic, people-centered globalisation.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q7. The inaugural World Social Forum was held in January 2001 in Porto Alegre, Brazil, as a civil-society counterweight to the corporate World Economic Forum in Davos.

Answer: (A)

Sol. Q8. The 4th World Social Forum met in Mumbai, India, in January 2004, marking the first time the global conclave was hosted outside Brazil.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q9. In July 1991, the Narasimha Rao government launched the New Economic Policy (LPG), dismantling industrial licensing and opening the Indian economy to foreign capital.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q10. India successfully fought biopiracy battles in international patent offices, revoking or modifying foreign commercial patents granted on Neem, Turmeric, and Basmati rice.

Answer: (B)

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Q3 option A	Confusing homogenisation with heterogenisation	Homogenisation creates **uniform Western culture**; heterogenisation creates **creative local hybridity**.
Q5 option C	Confusing Seattle with Davos	Davos is where the corporate WEF meets; Seattle was the site of the 1999 anti-WTO protests.
Q7 option B	Using the 2004 venue for the 2001 inaugural WSF	The 1st WSF was held in **Porto Alegre, Brazil** (2001); the 4th was in **Mumbai, India** (2004).
Q8 option A	Picking New Delhi instead of Mumbai	The 2004 World Social Forum took place in **Mumbai**, not New Delhi.
Q9 option B	Using Rajiv Gandhi's year instead of 1991	The full structural LPG reforms were officially rolled out in July 1991 by P.V. Narasimha Rao and Dr. Manmohan Singh.

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